



YASBANT NEGI

**JOINT EFFORT:**  
Mayawati with  
the leaders of  
the Third Front

Shahid Siddiqui are the Muslim faces.

Her social adaptability is matched by her ruthless pragmatism. In 1993, she supported the Mulayam Singh Yadav Government. She ditched him within 18 months. She struck an alliance with the Congress only to break it later and took BJP as her coalition supporter. She became chief minister with the outside support of BJP twice but she never let the party dictate terms. Soon after winning the last assembly elections, she flirted with the Congress to consolidate her power and got some temporary reprieve from the Centre in the cases pending against her. And all the while, she exploited the enmity between the SP and the Congress. When she realised the nu-

clear deal was about to bring the UPA Government down, she saw another window of opportunity opening before her. Although it was J. Jayalalithaa who forced Atal Bihari Vajpayee to face a vote of confidence in 1999, it was actually Mayawati who caused NDA's defeat in the Parliament. On the day of voting, she met Vajpayee and assured her party's support. Once inside the House, she changed her mind. This time around, she was pretty sure of voting out the Manmohan regime in the House. She even weaned away six of the 39 SP MPs. It was not the failure of her manoeuvring skills but desertions from NDA that saved the UPA Government. There is a method in her every move. In pursuit of power, Mayawati dumps, courts, woos, betrays... Nothing is sacred, no one is indispensable, and any alliance is negotiable. Permanency of principles is for the less ambitious. Mayawati's project in Dalits' upliftment is not for winning the Nobel Prize in Peace, but for getting into that piece of real estate on Race Course Road. There is no bigger prize for her.

**A**s the magnetic centre of an emerging coalition, she thinks the prize is now within reach, with a little help from the dependents. In her calculation, if the assembly trends are repeated in the General Elections, BSP will win around 55 seats in her state, and another 15 outside Uttar Pradesh—and that is quite a tally. She also hopes to defeat Congress candidates in at least 75 constituencies in the rest of India. BSP and its allies are sure of winning 110 seats from the states of Haryana, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Jharkhand, West Bengal, Kerala and some smaller states. The UNPA is aiming at a target of 180 so that it can become the single largest pre-poll alliance after the elections. Still it may require another 90, which the alliance hopes will come from either BJP or Congress. The UNPA is betting on Congress—finally secularism will save the day. Since her votes are transferable, she is one leader who can make a big difference in any election. She has chosen the allies according to their caste value. Both Gowda and Naidu represent forward communities in their respective states. By having a pre-poll alliance with them, she stands to gain few seats by putting up her Dalit candidates who can win the support of upper castes—a repeat of Uttar Pradesh. It is for the first time that she has accepted Ajit Singh as her possible electoral ally. He commands a sizable following among rich peasantry and Jats, who have always been at loggerheads with Dalits. In Maharashtra also, she has taken advantage of Dalits' anger against the UPA following the

**ABHISHEK  
SINGHVI**

Congress Spokesperson

“The top post requires a clean image, absence of a history of monetary legal hassles and a vision for the country that must rise above one's own personal ambition.”